

Lesson 2: Schwa: The Lazy Vowel Sound

Stage 4 · Lesson 2 · rule-intro

Warm-Up: Phonogram Flash Review

Flash all 75 phonograms. Focus: schwa

New Learning: Schwa — The Lazy Vowel Sound

What Is Schwa?

Schwa is the most common vowel sound in English. It sounds like a tiny, lazy "uh" — /ə/. Your mouth is relaxed, your tongue is in the middle. It's the sound you make when you don't try very hard.

Where Does Schwa Happen?

Schwa ONLY appears in **unstressed** syllables. That means the syllable where you DON'T put the emphasis.

Word	Stressed Syllable	Unstressed Syllable (Schwa!)
a·bout	BOUT (/bowt/)	a → /ə/
sev·en	SEV (/sev/)	en → /ən/
pen·cil	PEN (/pen/)	cil → /səl/
but·ton	BUT (/but/)	ton → /tən/
cir·cus	CIR (/ser/)	cus → /kəs/

The Schwa Surprise

Here's the amazing (and tricky) thing: **ANY vowel can say schwa!** A, E, I, O, U — all of them can make the /ə/ sound in an unstressed syllable.

Schwa Hunt

Which letter says schwa in each word?

Word	Schwa Letter	Say Normally	Say-to-Spell
about	a	/ə-bout/	/ā-bout/
seven	e (second e)	/sev-ən/	/sev-ĕn/
pencil	i	/pen-səl/	/pen-sĭl/
button	o	/but-ən/	/but-ŏn/
circus	u (second u)	/ser-kəs/	/ser-kŭs/

Why Say-to-Spell Matters

If you try to spell 'about' by sound, you might write 'ubout' — because schwa can be spelled by ANY vowel. Say-to-spell lets you HEAR the true spelling: /ā-bout/ tells you it's an A.

Spelling Analysis

Word	Phonograms Used	Rules Applied	Say-to-Spell
about	a (/ə/→/ā/ say-to-spell), b (/b/), ou (/ow/), t (/t/)	Rule 31: schwa in unstressed syllable	/ā-bout/
seven		Rule 31	/sev-ĕn/

Word	Phonograms Used	Rules Applied	Say-to-Spell
	s (/s/), e (/ě/), v (/v/), e (/ə/→/ě/), n (/n/)		
pencil	p (/p/), e (/ě/), n (/n/), c (/s/), i (/ə/→/ĭ/), l (/l/)	Rule 31 + Rule 1 (c=/s/)	/pen-sĭl/
button	b (/b/), u (/ŭ/), t (/t/), t (/t/), o (/ə/→/ŏ/), n (/n/)	Rule 31	/but-ŏn/

Reading Practice

about seven pencil button circus animal family banana

I am about seven. My pencil has a button. The circus has animals. My family eats bananas.

Quick Check

1. What is schwa? (*The lazy /ə/ sound in unstressed syllables.*)
2. Which vowels can say schwa? (*ALL of them — a, e, i, o, u.*)
3. What's the say-to-spell of 'about'? (*ā-bout!*)

Next lesson: Lesson 3: Say-to-Spell: Unlocking Schwa

Practice at home: Find 5 schwa words in a book. Say each one normally, then say-to-spell.